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MTWT PRESENTS:

LIFE AND TIMES OF A CORRECTIONAL OFFICER

RE: Florida Department of Corrections

**By R. Mark Shepard
(Introduction)**

It does not matter what an inmate has done in the past, or was doing at the time that he is being chastised for. Whether it is for doing something wrong, for not obeying the rules or regulations, or even for 'disrespecting an officer', it doesn't matter...

It makes no difference if the inmate is weak or strong mentally or physically, or if he is, or has been in the past, the most violent inmate in the system BECAUSE...

It is the Officer's responsibility in any situation to maintain himself in a Professional and Human Manner, and to not let others take advantage of him in ANY WAY.

It is not the job of the Correctional Officer in any Rank or Supervisory capacity to give orders to inflict undue pain or punishment, or to cause injury, and sometimes even be the cause of Death to someone JUST BECAUSE....

The job of the Correctional Officer is to *Maintain Care and Custody* of an Inmate.

Even if the Officer is worried about losing his or her job, or afraid of being chastised because he or she did not *Follow Through* or *Carry Out* the DIRECT ORDER from the Supervisor to do the unjust, or if the officer is nervous not to obey the order of Corporal Punishment of Pain, it is not an officer's job JUST BECAUSE a superior says so....

Myself and Sgt. Tom found this out personally. What you are about to read are indeed FACTS; it is Public Record, and with a clear conscious, myself and Sgt. Tom - instead of being Certified Correctional Officers - are now, in Fact, Certified Convicted Felons JUST BECAUSE we in Fact told the Truth and Maintained our own Self-Discipline as Correctional Officers.

We are Not hiding any issues of our own, nor the Fact that we never Punched, Kicked or hit an inmate. All of our 'Uses or Force' on Inmates were investigated thoroughly and found to be 'By the Book, and still exist as Public record with the Department Of Corrections, and were approved by the Department of Corrections.

The uses of Forces that have never been reported were those of Spontaneous Actions of Force, helping other Officers who were attacked by inmates, or helping control the actions of inmates who were about to get into serious Trouble by starting a riot or just beating someone to Death.

The time span for the stories is about 10 years from 1987 to 1997. And most of the stories took place at Charlotte CI, and some at Desoto CI.

The Inmate I went to court over was John Edwards. Frank Valdes and John Edwards are 2 Inmates who didn't deserve to be treated like that. It just escapes me to think that those GUARDS actually did those horrific things to those inmates with a good conscious. But like the Nurse, most of the officers from Charlotte have had either heart attack's, or something bad has been happening to them.

Anything else I have forgotten, or info you need please let me know. Can't wait to get the good mail and the Negative, and to respond. Yes I mean after all, they know who wrote the book, so yes include my email address.

Like I said, anything I can do to help, please let me know.

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LIFE AND TIMES OF A CORRECTIONAL OFFICER

By R. Mark Shepard

(Chapter 1)

According to the Florida Department of Corrections, the Job of Correctional Officer - means ANYONE who is Male or Female, young or old, Black or White, Short or Tall, weak or Strong, in the mind or of Stature, who may join the Department of Corrections.

NOW, don't get me wrong, some of these Higher-Ups have an understanding of what it is like to work on a prison yard, facing 600 to 900 Angry Convicts, or inmates who don't care if they hurt, mane or even kill you: Or to be inside the walls of a confinement unit being confronted on a One-to-One basis with an angry, out-of-control Convict or Inmate.

And then there are those Higher-Ups who make the BIG decisions, those Who have Never, Ever stepped Foot on a Prison Yard in their life.

These are the Educators, and the Scholars, with so much education and knowledge that they are promoted to the Administrative Level Positions, and these people out there are supposed to know what's best for us inside the prison Fences and Walls. These people will tell the everyday Correctional Officer what to do, and how to do it.

These Higher-Ups will tell new officers that they will be trained to be the best, and that, if they do not meet the Requirements established by the Guidelines that have been set forth, they will not make it.

But what they do not tell you will not hurt you, RIGHT? As long as you have a piece of paper with your name on it saying that you graduated from some High School, or some sort of night course, YOU WILL BE HIRED!! If you can walk, talk and have no Felony Convictions [in some cases], you will basically be hired on the spot.

Yes, there are some things you must pass before being hired on as a Correctional Officer; There's the predictable Drug Test, and let's see... That's about it.

Unlike most states that put candidates through Law Enforcement Schooling before they take their first step behind the prison Fences or Walls, the Florida Department of Corrections will interview you for the job, hire you, send you to get your Uniform and then tell you to report the next day for duty. Or, in some cases, if they are really hurting for warm bodies, OOP's, I should say, Correctional Officers, they will tell you to "Report at Midnight, and see the Shift Supervisor".

Most of the time the Higher-Ups forget to tell the Shift Lieutenant or Captain that they will have NEW Trainees on Shift, or maybe they just didn't get that sticky note.

With no Prior Knowledge or training these New Correctional Officers are given their assignments, and told to go to work.

Now, even if you don't have any prior knowledge of Corrections or what it is all about, or what it is period, they tell you that this job is all about Rules and Regulations, but you must understand, that it is Basically and Mainly about common sense First. Then you and the others can follow the rules and regulations. It is about Verbal Communication, and the other part of the job is all a HANDS-ON type of environment. During the course of this book, hearing some of the outlandish stories, which in fact are TRUE FACTS, you will understand why I Boldly Write "HANDS ON".

This job is not for the weak of Heart or, as my Partner, Sgt. Tom would say, If you are the least bit afraid of seeing a fight, or being in a fight, or seeing Blood, whether it is yours or someone else's, worried if you are going to get your teeth kicked in or get stabbed, or get Feces or Urine thrown on you, or get your Guts Stomped on, Sgt. Tom will say, you are weak, and you will be known to some as having "Uterus of the Heart". GO HOME, QUIT, because you will not Make it. You are just another warm expendable body for the Department Of Corrections.

The safety of the public is the Mainstay of the Department of Corrections. To make sure that ALL of the Inmates, and convicts are always locked up behind the miles of Razor wire and Fence. Besides maintaining a secure accurate account of all inmates.

Control of Inmates in the most important Tool of your job. After all, the ratio of inmate Versus Officer is only 27 or 35 to 1, and that depends on how many officers are on the Prison Yard at one time. Then the Ratio jumps to 70 or 80 to 1, or more.

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(Chapter 2)

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LIFE AND TIMES OF A CORRECTIONAL OFFICER

By R. Mark Shepard

(Chapter 2)

In the eyes of a Good Correctional Officer there is no such thing as COLOR, meaning Race, Creed or the Color of a Convict or inmate's skin. The word Color means anybody wearing the Color *BLUE*, the Color of the uniform worn by the Convict or inmate who is serving time in the State of Florida. That's the only Color a good Officer should and will see.

At times you will hear me refer to a Convicted Felon as a Inmate, or a Convict. Yes, there is a Difference, even though the Department of Corrections does not want Officers calling them 'Convicts' any more.

Explanation: A Convict is a person who knows what he has done, and he has excepted that, and he knows what he has to do to survive and how to do his time. He knows how to play the Correctional System, he knows how to get the good jobs within the system, and he will never disrespect an Officer, AND, he will abide by the Rules and Regulations to the extent that he will not get caught disobeying any of these rules, AND, if he does get caught, he will, usually, be Straight up with the officer and accept the Punishment that the system is handed out to him, when he breaks the Rules and Regulations.

Then there is the Inmate. He is the type of Person who is Sentenced to prison, whether it be for a short period of time or a long sentence. He does not know how to do his time. He does not know how to play the System, he does not know how to act and talk to an Officer when an officer tells him to do something, and basically he does not care. When he is told to do something, he is the one with the Bad Attitude, and disrespect in his voice, and he does not care if he has to fight an officer or go to the Confinement Unit just because he was either asked a simple question or was told to do something according to the rules and regulations of the Institution and refused.

Let me shock you and tell you that there are numerous beatings and assaults on Correctional Officers and Staff... NO? I didn't think that would shock you. Again, I will tell you, it's all in the communication amongst each other, whether it be talking to inmates or amongst the staff. There ARE and ALWAYS will be Correctional Officers who think they are invincible, or if you will, SUPERMEN, because the inmates are not supposed to touch them.

So often Sgt. Tom and myself have seen officers talk to inmates and Convicts alike as you have seen in the movies of the 30's, 40's, 50's and even the 60's. You know, the officers in all of their Super Powers and Stupidity, will say something like, "Hey boy, get over here right now", or "You better get your Stupid ass over here".

These Super Officers have ZERO skills in Communication. Some of the Officers think that just because they get to go home after 8 hours on the job, nothing will ever happen to them. They forget that they are doing time, locked up in the system just like that Convict or inmate, but only for 8 hours a day, instead of 24 hours a day, 7 days a week.

One day an officer, fresh out of the Military, you know the kind - he's the one with that High and tight haircut, knowing in his own mind that he is one of those SUPERMEN - he was on the prison yard amongst other officers and about 450 to 600 inmates and convicts. He was verbally disrespected, and this of course did not please the officer. This Brave young Superman of an officer {Mckenzie}, went up to the inmate and slapped him with all he had.

With approximately 8 to 10 Officers on the yard at the time, this could have turned into one of the Biggest Major Disturbances, or should I say, the Biggest Riot that the Florida Prison System would have ever seen. But because of a couple of Experienced officers who had Excellent Communication Skills, the officer who slapped the inmate got away with just a minor beating.

I'm not saying that you have to Coddle, and be pleasant or treat inmates or convicts with total respect. Most of the inmates are in the prison system because they, as you know, raped, murdered or dealt drugs, or Molested children, and the list goes on.

The attitudes of the Supervisors have an effect and carry a Positive or Negative affect down to the officers and others that work under him or her. The O.I.C. (officer in charge), which consists of either a Lieutenant or Captain, are also Human and every once in a while comes to work with a Negative attitude, just like everybody else who has problems.

The officers of course, pick up quickly on this, and they know that they are in for a very rough day if a Supervisor comes to work with that Negative Attitude, talking down to officers before the Shift even Starts. Sometimes, or I should say, most of the time, no matter what capacity the supervisor comes in, they forget where they have come from. Most of the officers know how to do their jobs, and they do it without letting the O.I.C. get to them. But there is that small percentage of officers that let the O.I.C. get to them, and it sticks with them... Unfortunately.

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([Chapter 3](#))

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LIFE AND TIMES OF A CORRECTIONAL OFFICER

By R. Mark Shepard

(Chapter 3)

I have said before, protecting the public is the Main concern of the Department of Corrections. Most of the escapes from any prison consist of an inmate, that just walks away from an outside work squad. Those are the inmates the public sees working along the side of the road who have supposedly earned the right to be outside of the Prison fences with the public. These inmates usually have very little time left on their sentence.

All outside work squads consist of 1 Correctional officer, and about 4 to 5 inmates. An inmate who has earned the right to be on a work squad, may decide on his own that it is time to take it upon himself to see the Countryside, and just walk away when the officer is not looking. And yes, he has undoubtedly planned this far in advance. But there are those other inmates who have a spontaneous instinct about them, and just get tired of it all, no matter how little time is left on his sentence, and just walk away.

No matter what rank officer you are, you always think of the worst possible thing that could happen, or what the inmate would do to someone when he is desperate and running for his Life.

When the call comes through from the Work Squad Officer that an inmate has walked away (escaped), there is a bit of time that elapses because of the procedures that the Institution has to follow. After everyone has been contacted, and it is verified that an inmate has actually escaped, and everyone is put into place, the Hunt begins.

One day, this particular inmate walked away from his work squad but had no idea where he was or where he was going. He ran until he found a small mobile home development, and still not knowing what he was doing or where he was about to go, and not even knowing his own motive, this inmate broke into a mobile home and apparently went straight for the liquor cabinet.

By now there were as many officers as possible beating the brush, the K-9 unit was working it's dogs, the Sheriffs' Office was conducting road blocks, stopping vehicles with the help of the Highway Patrol, and Correctional Officers in Vehicles were searching the area that the inmate fled from.

The Colonel and a Sergeant had left the Prison headed for the Main road. Approximately 2 miles from the Institution, they noticed a black man riding a bicycle on this road. Having Photo Circulars of the escaped inmate in their hand, the Colonel and the sergeant could not believe their eyes, there he was!

The inmate had broken into this mobile home, and taken a bottle of liquor. The only transportation he could find was a bicycle and he was fleeing to freedom. The inmate was traveling south on the main road, drinking his stolen 5th of liquor, enjoying the view, thinking he was headed south, going to Miami. But when he turned left onto the road, he had inadvertently headed back to the Institution, ignoring the Big Green Sign that says, "Correctional Institution".

Of course the Colonel and the sergeant grabbed the inmate from the bicycle, handcuffed him and gave him a free ride back to the Prison Institution. This particular inmate had a total of 2 months left on his entire sentence. Like I said, some inmates plan their escapes, and some DON'T.

Then there are inmates who have become Institutionalized. These are people who have been in prison for a long period of time: We call them repeat offenders, and I mean *repeat offenders*. These people actually love the Prison life because they have a life time partner inside that they cannot live without, they become adapted to the way of life inside: Three meals a day, free medical, free dental, not much work, and their Partner, otherwise known as their daddy, cannot live without them.

One particular inmate who was a repeat offender, begged and pleaded with his classification officer to put him on an outside work squad. The Classification officer was very reluctant because this inmate had been on work squads before and had

walked away from them before. The inmate promised the classification officer that he would 'Never do that again', that he wanted a chance to prove himself and get out one day and make something of himself. The Classification Officer and the Assistant Superintendent reviewed his case and felt that he deserved a chance, ONE MORE TIME. This inmate was called out to the back gate, and released to an outside squad once again.

That DAY, once again, that same inmate walked away (escaped) from the work squad. This inmate knew what he was doing, because he only wanted to be out for a short period of time before he wanted to be caught. It was about 2 to 3 months before they caught up with him. Naked on the beach 60 to 70 miles north of the Prison Institution.

When questioned by the investigators, as to why he did it again, he told them he had escaped to make sure he would get more time, because he could not live on the outside away from his prison daddy.

The inmate was immediately transported to another prison in North Florida. This did not bother him to be separated from his daddy, because he told me that one day he would meet up with him somewhere in the system, and they would be back together again.

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(Chapter 4)

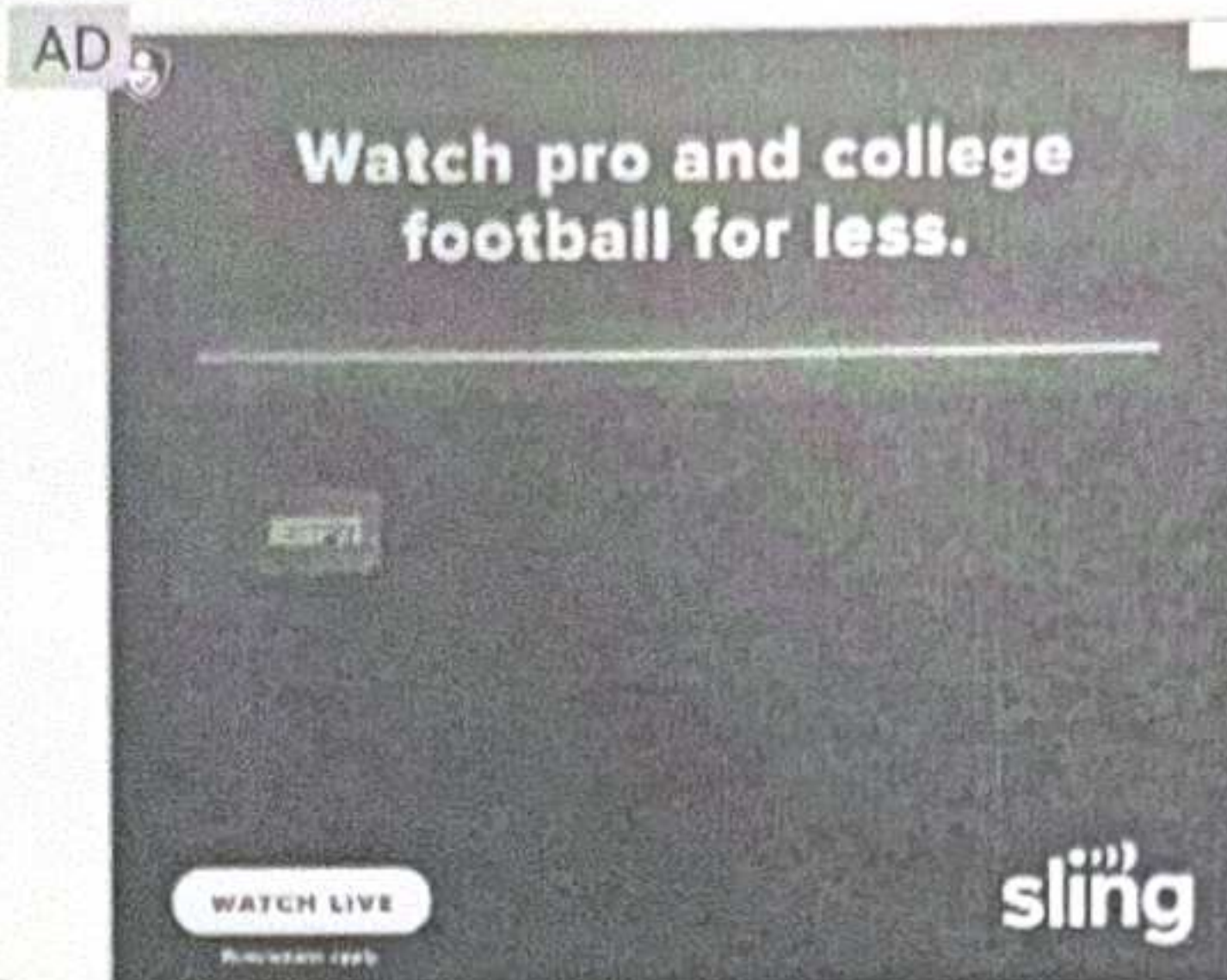
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LIFE AND TIMES OF A CORRECTIONAL OFFICER

By R. Mark Shepard

(Chapter 4)

Another of many escapes, were three Haitian men who were in prison for Numerous crimes, such as Trafficking in Cocaine, 1st Degree Murder, Kidnapping, Assault, and the list goes on.

All three of these men had Natural Life Sentences. All three knew how to play the system with the right attitude. No matter what an Officer said to them or asked them to do, or what task to perform, it was always, 'Yes sir', and 'No sir'. This attitude would eventually gain them the right job, or should I say the job that they wanted all along: A chance to work in food service.

At the time, the Kitchen was operated by an outside company, contracted by the state to run and be responsible for all of the meals served to the Inmates at this particular prison. It did not pay much to the Inmates, only about .32 cents an hour, but for some it was a dream job, especially when you had no family on the outside sending you money each week or per month for Personal Items. But these 3 inmates had more on their minds than just the small money factor.

The food service company would place all of it's garbage inside a fenced area on the prison compound and a local sanitation truck would drive onto the compound after being searched thoroughly from the Back Gate. These searches of vehicles was just a routine security check so the prison could try to eliminate any contraband from the outside coming into the prison.

Once the truck was checked and cleared from the back gate area, the truck was escorted by an officer to the food service area. The Sanitation truck would quickly lift the large dumpsters up with its forks, and dump hundreds of pounds of old, Nasty, Stinking week-old garbage into the back of the truck.

Then the truck would be escorted again from the food service area to the back gate where it would under go another rigorous inspection. The back gate officer would have to stand on top of the garbage truck with a long steel pointed probe, pushing it through the garbage, making sure that no one is hiding in the back of the truck. After the probing was complete, the driver would be ordered to compact the garbage, which was done with strong hydraulic Rams. This insured that if anyone was inside, they would be crushed.

When the inspection of the truck was complete, the truck would be on the way to the county dump.

A Head count of all inmates was done three times a day, and some shifts had more frequent counts. This particular count was right before Noon, before the inmates were released for the noon meal. The Count kept coming up short. Three inmates were missing from three different locations. All of the outside work squads were accounted for, and the kitchen kept coming up with 3 missing Inmates ... the Hunt began.

Many hours later, after all of the surrounding law enforcement agencies were notified, one of the agencies notified the prison that they had 3 Haitian Males, 'that smelled VERY BAD', in their custody.

The 3 inmates told the police officers that they had jumped in the dumpsters at the prison and waited for the truck. After surviving the fall from the dumpsters into the truck, the probing, the compacting of the garbage, and the dumping of themselves and the garbage at the dump, they made their way south approximately 25 miles and were going to try to get on a boat and to back to Haiti.

Needless to say that the Policy of the Outside garbage truck coming ONTO the compound to empty the dumpsters changed, drastically.

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LIFE AND TIMES OF A CORRECTIONAL OFFICER

By R. Mark Shepard

(Chapter 5)

The greatest escape for this particular institution is one that I will never forget, because I saw this escape unfold first hand; I was there from the time it happened, and stayed until the end.

The Institution was building a New Church Chapel for all of The Wonderfully Religious Inmates who had seen the light - and even for those who have not. All of the Materials to build the Chapel were brought in mainly by the Outside Grounds Personnel who worked for the State.

On one late afternoon, one of the State's employees who worked with Minimum Custody Inmates on the Construction Squad was calling it quits for the day at the Chapel. (OH, did I forget to mention that this new chapel was being built ON the compound, inside the prison area?)

The State employee was driving the State dump truck from the Chapel area to the back gate (Unescorted by any Correctional Officer). I had just walked past the truck and asked him if everything was OK, and the State Employee said, "Yes, everything is fine". The truck had almost made it to the back gate when Officer Tim called me on the radio and asked me why the Dump truck was stopped. At that instant, I turned around and saw an inmate open the driver's door of the truck and pull the State Employee to the ground. At the same time, 2 other inmates jumped into the bed of the truck with the inmate who was now driving. I immediately radioed the Control Room that there was an escape in progress, and the dump truck sped off towards the back gate. Two very large rolling gates, approximately 18 feet high, were the only 2 things in the way of the truck and the outside world for these inmates.

When the truck hit the first gate, I figured that the gate would surely slow down the truck, or at least stop it before it hit the second gate. I was wrong: The first gate snapped like a twig and the inmate driver lost control of the truck for a brief period. It looked as if he would hit one of the Steel I Beams that held the gates together, but at the last second, he straightened out the truck's direction and hit the second gate with the force of hitting the first gate and almost lost control, did lose speed. It was for sure that the second gate would hold, I figured... Well, I was wrong again. It too snapped like a twig folding up, but this time with not as much force as the other gate. The impact crushed the hood of the truck and forced it onto the windshield, which made it very difficult for the driver to see where he was going. The truck continued onto a dirt road back between the outside warehouse and the outside maintenance building, which led towards the Sewer Plant. Now, he was driving down the dirt road with his head stuck out of the window, going as fast as he could go. The inmate driver ended up running into a dead-end... the Prison Dog Yard.

In the meantime, one of the 4 Gun trucks and Lt. Jesse were in pursuit of the truck. When the truck finally stopped, all of the inmates started to run as fast as they could. Lt. Jesse took aim with the 12 gauge shotgun, and shot 2 inmates with one shot (lucky). The other two inmates kept running, but not knowing where they were going, they ran towards the Institution's Base living quarters where the Superintendent's house and other employee's homes were.

Other armed officers were already in the area, and beating the brush for the other two inmates. As two of the officers walked by the superintendent's house and around the backyard, they were discussing the possibility of seeing the other inmates and that they would, of course, be shot on sight, no questions asked. As one officer made that particular statement, they were walking by a big hammock that someone had put up in their backyard. One of the inmates had rolled himself inside the hammock and was so afraid that he was going to be shot, that he hollered, "Don't shoot, I give up".

The officers, who hadn't even looked towards the hammock, couldn't believe what they had heard. This left only one more to be captured.

The local Sheriff's Helicopter was already in the area, and as it got darker, another helicopter was brought to the institution from another agency. Both helicopters searched the area all night long with their lights and Night Vision and Heat detection equipment.

One of the Helicopters kept hovering over one area directly behind the Institution because he kept picking up traces of some kind of body heat with his sensor. The officers and the K-9 units searched every inch of the Institution grounds all the way to the Interstate and other local roads, back and forth all night long. The inmate wasn't found.

The next morning on the way to work, a Sergeant who lives South of the Institution was on the Interstate by the prison, when he saw someone sticking their head up out of the tall grass and looking around as if he were lost or looking for someone or something. Having a cell phone, the sergeant immediately called the prison and notified them of what he had seen.

The K-9 unit and many other officers were on this inmate so fast he did not know what hit him. This inmate was an Ex-Military man, and he had dug himself in the ground so that no one would find him. But not being familiar with Florida and it's different types of habitat, he did not know about the palmetto bugs, water moccasins, armadillos, red ant's or any of the other hundreds of biting insects. His skin had so many bites on it, and he was so eaten up from the creatures in the earth chewing on him, that he couldn't wait to get back in his prison cell.

The only transportation from the swamp-like land back to the institution was by the prison 4-wheel drive truck which had dog cages in the bed. The inmate was handcuffed and stuffed inside one of the dog cages. The superintendent and the upper brass had sent a new transport van to the rear of the Institution, where the road met the swamp. Because of all the press that was present at the prison, they didn't want them to see this inmate stuffed inside a dog cage. The superintendent and the others didn't want the public to get the wrong image of the prison. I mean after all, they didn't want anyone to think that they had abused the poor inmate after all of the destruction and mayhem he and the others had caused, RIGHT!

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(Chapter 6)

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LIFE AND TIMES OF A CORRECTIONAL OFFICER

By R. Mark Shepard

(Chapter 6)

The public is already worried and frightened enough trying not to think about anymore inmates escaping from a Maximum security prison, putting themselves and their loved ones in danger. They really have no idea what goes on inside the Fences of the Institution on a day to day basis. And it is really a day to day basis, because no one day has ever been the same for the Correctional Officer or the Inmate, even though the inmate has to basically do the same thing, in the same place 24 hours a day, 7 days a week; living in the same cell, going to the same chow hall, living in accordance with the same rules and regulations, looking at the same familiar faces of each inmate day after day, month after month, and year after year, most of them will be there for the rest of their lives.

As I have said before, if an inmate cannot get the job he wants right away, he will play the system, or just wait it out knowing that someday the opportunity will arise and he will be in the exact position he has planned for all along.

For Example, the job as a Canteen Operator, having his own key to a store of his own, that he runs and operates, which is set up by the State. He sells such items as soda, candy, chips, radio batteries, orange juice, raincoats, and all kinds of hygiene products, and the list goes on. Cigarettes and the few items that I have listed are made more affordable to the inmate.

These items used to be purchased by the inmate with real money that an inmate could carry on him, although the funds that he could carry would of course be limited. The Department of Corrections came to the conclusion that if they took the money off of the compound, a lot of problems such as paying someone for the making and distribution of homemade alcohol, or paying each other for sex favors, paying for drugs smuggled in, gambling debts and other Ill-gotten bootie that an inmate could do, or make money on would be less of a problem.

The idea was that the inmate would have an Identification Card with a Security strip on the back of the card. It was a good idea. This was to cut down on all, and more, of the problems I just mentioned, because this would be the control the state needed to handle the inmates' money and everything would be fairly under control, Right?.....Wrong again.

The drug deals, the homemade wine, sex favors, gambling and every other type of scam continued on at full force, but with new twists. Now the average inmate had to think a lot harder about how to get his money. Some of this resorted right back to the fabulous job of the Canteen Operator. For instance, when an inmate would bet on a football game, he would bet a few packs of cigarettes, cherry cakes or any other canteen items that the Bookie would demand. The Canteen operator would go along with whatever he could get away with, just as long as he made out in favors of his own, he demanded to play the New system. We, the Correctional Officers, are not so gullible as to think that there would be no more REAL green money on the compound.

On a day to day basis real money is found on the prison compound and confiscated. When the money is confiscated, it is put into what the state calls an Inmate Welfare Fund. This fund pays for things such as TV's when they are broken, equipment for the recreation program for the inmates, the music room for the inmates, who came from the street actually knowing how to play an instrument.

Now you are probably saying to yourself, how does the Real money that is not suppose to be on the compound get into the hands of the inmate? Usually through the Visiting Park, on the weekends, by inmates who are called 'Mules'. These inmates have visitors bring money, drugs or what ever they are told to carry. Most of the items that are muled in are drugs with money wrapped around them with many layers of plastic electrical tape. Electrical tape is used because it is a softer kind of tape than any other kind, so that when the Mule puts the Item in his Rectum, it is supposed to be easier to slid in, and easier to slide out.

Another way to get drugs into the prison is inside a condom, also called a balloon. A small amount of drugs are put into a condom in the visitor's mouth, and when the visitor kisses the inmate, they transfer the drugs internally. After a period of time, as nature takes its course, the condom passes through the system and when the condom comes out, it is opened up and the drugs are then distributed.

This of course is very risky for the Mule because the balloon could break and the whole amount of drugs in the balloon could hospitalize the inmate or it could kill him with an overdose. The reason the condom is used is that it is supposed to be more durable than a regular plastic balloon, but inmates have been known to be hospitalized or die from this.

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(Chapter 7)

Getting back to the inmates that have to do what they have to do to survive in the Prison System: One particular inmate that I remember waited for his turn in the System and worked his way into a job in Food Service. This inmate had been trained throughout the years in the Culinary Arts. He was an Excellent Baker, and could make Biscuits that would melt in your mouth, not that I would *know*, this was just hearsay.

This Inmate had multiple Life sentences, and had been in The Prison System for the past 17 years. Most of the prisons in The State were run by the prison staff. But this particular prison had a contract with an outside agency. These outside contracts sometimes cause problems because the outside people who are contracted to work in the Kitchen are not Correctional Officers, and are not security minded. They don't understand the Environment that they are in and they do not understand the thinking of an inmate.

As all outside food service companies do, they hire women as well as men to fill the positions that are needed, but they do not think of the risks and dangers that they are putting an untrained female into. This of course leads back to the story of the skilled inmate in the kitchen.

He was working with one of those female employees and got friendly enough that they were on a first name basis, (which is NEVER supposed to happen). One day I saw this particular inmate go to work. At the same time, I saw the female worker walking into the food service building. It wasn't even 15 minutes later when a call came from the food service director that an inmate had one of his employees' held hostage in the dry storage room.

The inmate had methodically planned this kidnapping very well. The room he took her to only had one door which he barricaded with heavy boxes of canned goods. The room had no windows, and the locked Escape Hatch in the ceiling was blocked with even more boxes of canned goods. The only door in the room did have a window made of 3/4 inch Lexan, only the strongest plastic that they could purchase. He was barricaded in, and set up for a very long period of time.

The Female employee apparently had gotten so friendly with this inmate, that she had given him a scarf with the scent of her favorite perfume on it that he could keep forever. Seeing that he was never getting out of prison, and she thought that he was such a nice person, and he treated her with so much respect, it would not hurt to give him something, and she figured that there would not be any problem. Well, something happened with her newfound friendship with the inmate, because she apparently asked for her scarf back and he inevitably said, 'NO!' Not handling rejection well, and thinking that he would never see her again if she quit, he decided that it was no skin off of his nose if he killed her and then killed himself.

After the prison officials, Hostage Negotiators and Inspectors from the State arrived, hours of talking and demands were made and met. He had demanded a coffee pot and a phone so he could call his mother. A few Professional hostage negotiators tried to talk to the inmate. Only one, after hours of talking, having communication skills beyond her normal reach, she talked him into releasing the female hostage. The next step was to retrieve the distraught inmate.

The local swat team was already in the compound waiting to go in if the Prison CERT Team had any problems. With 4 officers ready and armed to shoot him if he did not comply with any order of surrender which was given by the head prison inspector, the inmate complied. He was handcuffed and taken out with no further incident.

As time went by, I learned that this was not the first time that this inmate had taken a female employee hostage. The good old Classification Department strikes again. I don't mean to come down on the Classification Department so hard, BUT... this was not the only incident of Mistakes by them, Trust me.

In fairness to the Classification Department, I must talk about some of the other Departments who have done such a fine job in the system. The Medical Department comes to mind. It is supposed to be one of the most Professional departments, not

only in the Prison system, but also in the eyes of everyone outside of the system. All of the employees who are hired by the State, be it in the Medical Department, Classification, Security or whatever Department it is, go through a Rigorous background check.

I'm not really sure where to start, when it comes to talking about the Medical Department, you know, being a lowly Correctional officer and all.

The CHO (Chief Health Officer) has a tremendous responsibility, as a Doctor making decisions would. After all, where else could a Doctor go and make a salary in excess of \$120,000 a year, with no overhead, and not have to pay Malpractice insurance, which the state pays, or have to pay for any supplies or amenities that is also supplied by the state? The Doctor's secretary, who is also a Trained Professional and gets paid a decent wage, deserves a lot of credit. She makes decisions that the Doctor has ordered her to, like setting up her paperwork to make sure that everything is PER the State's Requirements. This means that the secretary must come in on Saturdays, on her own time and catch up on the tedious and tremendous amount of work.

After a month of coming to work on Saturdays, taking time to clean her office and the doctor's office, along with her regular duties, this secretary began to call the same inmate to her Office to help her every Saturday at precisely the same time. Being security minded, suspicious and generally nosy, Captain Jim, Sgt. Fred and I had already figured out that this was definitely not the normal routine duties of a doctor's secretary, even though the doctor, herself, gave the secretary permission to do this.

Capt. Jim appropriated the necessary keys to get into the Medical Department and, with the captain leading the way, we waited for a short period of time before we entered the doctor's office. When we arrived at the office door, we could not see the secretary nor the inmate, who was so kind as to take the time out of his day every week to help the secretary.

We entered through the secretary's door and walked to the doctor's office, where lo and behold, there they were. The secretary was butt naked on top of the doctor's desk, along with the butt naked inmate making mad passionate Love. Sgt. Fred ordered the inmate to Stop, and not move a muscle (imagine that).

After a few seconds, the secretary, and the inmate got dressed, and the secretary was escorted off of the compound, never to return. The Inmate was locked up in a Confinement Cell, and later transferred to another Institution. The Doctor was shocked that someone on her staff would have anything to do with a convicted criminal.

WELL... what she also didn't know was that there were two other female staff members, Registered Nurses, who were having Relations with inmates at the same time. Without going into a lot of boring details, both Nurses quit their jobs at the prison and married those inmates when they were finally released from prison. The First Nurse had 2 children by her wonderful convicted criminal husband, who divorced her later on and left her out in the cold. And the second Nurse who married her wonderful convicted criminal husband, went out of her loving way to send him to school so he could become a model citizen and a productive human being. He eventually left her at one of his family reunions, and ran away with an old lover, taking her money and checkbook, leaving her in debt up to her eye brows. OH, by the way both ex-husbands are back in Prison. Isn't Love Grand!.

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The Security Department has not been without their share of problems with bad decisions by the Captains and the Higher-Up's.

Once a Violent and out of control Inmate was placed in the Medical Ward of the prison which was called the SOS cell, (for violent and suicidal inmates). This inmate was not there just because he wanted to Kill himself, but because he was accused of something that he didn't do (say's he) and he didn't think that was fair, so he was trying to pick a fight with the colonel and several other Officers.

The SOS Cell is an 8 foot by 8 foot cell with nothing but 4 walls and a door, with that same $\frac{3}{4}$ inch lexan window. The inmate was on a 15 minute watch, with a Correctional Officer sitting outside of the cell documenting the inmate's every move.

All day this inmate was calm and serene, talking to himself and pacing about his cell, undoubtedly thinking of ways to get out.

When the evening shift arrived, the poor lonely inmate, who had nothing but a canvas wrap around his body, asked this Particular Captain if he would, PLEASE 'gives' him a bed to sleep in because he was cold, and he was sorry if he caused any Problems and he had seen the error of his ways. Feeling bad for the poor inmate, the Captain complied with the inmate's request, and gave him a nice Metal Hospital Bed.

The Night went by with no problems, and the morning too was calm. Until around Lunch time, which is when you-know-what hit the fan. This poor neglected inmate had spent all night long taking apart the retractable side rails of the old hospital bed. (I guess the night shift officer was also quiet and calm, and didn't see this). The call came across the radio, '10-24 (officer down)' in the Medical department.

When the inmate had finally gotten the side rail all of the way off, he kept beating it against the $\frac{3}{4}$ lexan window, and broke through it enough to where he could climb through the window, He then started breaking all of the glass windows in the Medical Department.

The Colonel, Captains and many officers ran to the Medical Department to assist the officer in trouble. The Captain had brought a Large canister of Mace with him, and with one shot of the Magnum canister of Mace, the inmate was through being Violent. This can has so much power that it will leave you standing alone in severe pain, or in his case, laying, crying in a pool of tears along with 3 other officers that the Captain had accidentally sprayed. Many officers, including myself, had to go home and shower, change uniforms and report back to work.

Nothing ever happened to the big hearted Captain who gave This inmate a bed, I'm not sure why, seeing this was one of the Biggest violations of Procedure any officer could possibly do. But the Politics inside the prison are just as bad as the politics On the outside.

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By R. Mark Shepard

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Another place on the Compound that deserves a lot of credit for being so security minded, is the Prison Library.

Now, you would think that this would be a place that there would be no problems at all. This is a place where inmates go to catch up on the News events, check out books to read, at a later date when they are locked up in their cell, or work on their legal cases, with the prison library legal assistant, whom They call the Jail house Lawyer. No difficulties in this area, RIGHT! You are right, there isn't, EXCEPT, for those darn big hearted state females employees who think that these poor Inmates are solely unjustly accused, and sentenced of a crime, That they didn't do, according to the inmates.

To go along with the story about the doctor's secretary, there was a Librarian whom also enjoyed the help of inmates to clean and straighten up her work area. This Librarian was a little different than the rest. She didn't tie herself down to just one inmate. Everyday at count time just before the Noon meal, This Librarian would always call in an out count from the library, to the control room, of at least 2 inmates that would have to be there to help her. Even as suspicious as we are, we did not catch this employee in the act.

She eventually went to the Prison Inspector and told him that she had been molested by one of the inmates who work for her. Her story changed a couple of times from Molestation to Rape. During the course of this investigation, the prison investigator interviewed myself and several other officers to see if we had seen anything out of the ordinary at any particular time. The one thing that EVERY officer had told the Inspector was that every time the Noon count was announced, the librarian would always keep 2 or more inmates in the library with her, and we could always see at least one or more at the front window, but not the other inmate or the Librarian.

The inmates were interviewed and put on a Polygraph Machine, to see if the story of the Librarian was true or not.

In all, the investigation turned out that the Librarian had lied About being molested or raped. But in fact, that she loved to Have sex with different inmates, and in the meantime, she also Had become pregnant. The problem with her being pregnant Is, that her husband was Sterile, so she had to have an out, as How to explain how she had become pregnant, and save face With her husband, so she figured that she had no other choice But to Holler, RAPE!

If it sounds like that women are a problem in the Men's prison facility, I'll let you make that decision. There are a FEW Women that are good, Professional Correctional Officers. These women have a different outlook and perspective on life in the prison system, and adapt themselves accordingly. The Few good Female officers are there for a career in Corrections. They are there to support their families and provide Health care for their Children, and themselves. After all, the state does, like any Government agency, have good insurance, and the pay is well above any other job, in the area. The only one thing that the state does, that NO Correctional Officer agrees with, is that they do not pay all of the Correctional Officers the same.

For example, As a Sergeant, I got paid X amount of dollars Working in the South West Florida Region, and a Sergeant in the Northern part of the State would be getting paid much less, just because of the area. And a Sergeant in the Very Southern part of the State would be getting paid a Considerable amount more than me and the Sergeant in the northern part of the State, just because of the area that the prison was built in. Someone in the head office, in all of his or her wisdom, came to some conclusion that it costs more to live in let's say Miami, than in Ocala. But, the Inmates are still the same, no matter where you live, or what part of the state you live in. If the Prison is built in the middle of a swamp, miles away from Civilization, the Institution therefore must pay even MORE money, just so officers they will stay, But, the Inmates are still the same.

Then we get back to the institution that has no problem in staffing officers, not because of the location, but because the officers are treated with respect, and they are allowed to do their jobs without the interference from the Higher Ups, unlike Some places, where some supervisors sit behind the desk and Micro-manage the officers, so they are unable to do their job Effectively. These Institutions that show officers respect are Very hard to get into, or transfer to, because these officers do Not quit or get fired, they Retire. But it's not fair to them to Receive a lower wage for doing their job effectively, but it's Suppose to be fair for the officer who gets paid more, and takes so much more abuse and Crap from his Supervisors, and is so unhappy with his or her job, that he or she wants to put in 10 years of Service instead of 20 years. The Region Directors, and the Secretary of Corrections don't see this, and Basically, DON'T CARE!.

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By R. Mark Shepard

(Chapter 10)

Getting away from the problems of the different Departments and the Department heads, employees and officers, the whole life as a Correctional officer is focused with being inside that fence, being with Convicts and inmates alike.

The hardest time for a correctional officer is upon entering the prison, and the stress level of an officer goes up as soon as he walks onto the Prison compound, and begins doing time with the inmates 8 hours a day.

You can be one of the nicest people around, but after you spend time with a few hundred inmates, and you ARE in contact with them 8 hours a day, 5 days a week, your nice attitude starts to deteriorate, and believe me, it does not take long. After all, this is REAL LIFE.

This is what happens when you get caught doing something you are really not supposed to be doing in LIFE. It's not as if you get caught stealing money from your mother's purse, or sealing hubcaps, or smoking a joint because someone dared you to: THIS IS IT! Spending your time in a Level 7 prison the rest of your life, never to get out, NEVER! As a Correctional Officer, if you don't think about that once in awhile, you will not get the Picture of how to do your job and do it effectively.

If a Fight breaks out on the prison yard, these inmates may be out to just get even. They will kill each other, and if you are in the way, they could care less if you are wearing a Blue inmate shirt, or a Brown Correctional Officer shirt. On any one day, at any one time, these convicted criminals, [some of whom] have no conscious about what they have done, could come up to any one Correctional Officer and stab you, or beat you to death and not blink twice.

The Superman of an Officer that I had mentioned earlier about slapping the inmate on the yard [Mckenzie], got off easy. The inmate he slapped didn't matter to the other inmates, but the inmates wanted that officer hurt or killed Because he was not a Professional Correctional Officer. AGAIN, He had Zero communication skills.

The inmates who cause problems with themselves, and others on the prison compound, are trying to survive in the only way that they know how, or were brought up to know, and they will be in prison for the rest of their Natural Life.

Everyone knows about gangs and the racial problems in the prison system, as it is the same on the outside. It's the 'Crips against the Bloods', the Folk nation against the people nation, the 'Blacks against the whites', the 'Latin kings' against all the rest, and the list goes on and on.

If a Correctional officer does not keep up with the multitude of different kinds of gangs and supremacist groups, he will not be doing his job effectively enough to stay alive on the compound for that 8 hours. And if he or she does not think about this, and have some kind of sense about how to handle it, He or SHE, WILL NOT SURVIVE AT ALL.

If you don't think for a minute that the Correctional Officer like myself, who has 20 plus years in Law enforcement, or even the officer who has 2 or 10 years in is not bothered by the Stabbing or the killing of an inmate or a massive fight among inmates, you are profoundly wrong. You need to walk a mile in my shoes, just for one day, and you will have a change of heart, or else you will tell yourself to leave, and probably never come back.

Quick thinking helps in situations, but sometimes things happen so fast that you just React and think later. One day in broad day light, I saw an inmate stabbing another inmate in the chest repeatedly, over and over again right in front of a housing unit.

While running as fast as I could, I saw another officer came out of the housing unit. He ran into one of the cells, and took a mattress off one of the bunks, ran outside and threw it on top of the inmate that was being stabbed. That is quick thinking, and because of the officer's quick thinking, the stabbed inmate actually lived. All of this took place in seconds, whether it was just quick thinking or quick reacting, it did save a life.

When inmates disrespect each other, they get even. Some inmates handle the situation so that you would not even know anything had happened. Other inmates might pay another inmate to do their dirty work for them. This is a situation that usually causes a Disturbance or a Riot on the compound. The stronger of the inmate would step to the inmate that disrespected his friend, just to find out what the problem was all about, to see if his friend had a legitimate complaint.

Of course the verbal argument usually begins. If it's verbal enough to attract the attention of other inmates, it's usually verbal enough to attract the attention of the Correctional Officer. If an officer with good communication skills and common sense steps in between the argument, sometimes he can be a good mediator between the two and help settle the problem. If the inmates respect the officer enough to know that he would not lie to them, then the problem would be solved.

The Key word here is *LIE*. This is one of the main things that an officer does not want to do to an inmate or Convict is LIE. From day 1, Sgt. Tom and I would tell inmates that we would NEVER lie to them. They might not like to hear what we have to say, but it would be the truth.

That Statement gives you more respect and CONTROL over an inmate than any fib or lie ever will. And if you think an inmate doesn't know whether you are lying to them or not, try it, and see what happens.

When inmates argue amongst themselves, most of the time you cannot do much about it, but handle the situation when it occurs.

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By R. Mark Shepard

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The inmates would also pick up and drop off their laundry on the way to eat because the laundry was located right next to the chow hall. One day while feeding the entire prison compound the noon meal, an Hispanic inmate ran past the chow hall, to the laundry line, and began cutting and stabbing another inmate as fast and as furious as he could, trying to kill him. This inmate had 2 homemade knives taped to his hands and wrists. It took myself and 4 other officers to stop this incident, and about 7 more officers, or more to handle the other 50 or 60 plus inmates, so the situation would not get out of control, anymore than it already was.

What happened was, that the inmate who got cut and stabbed had slapped and disrespected the other inmate about 2 weeks prior. It took 2 weeks for this inmate to sit and stew about what happened to him, all the time getting madder and madder. This just one incident where something happened that neither the Officers nor anyone else could predict or do, until it had happened.

The Struggle for Survival between the strong and the weak is much more enduring, because the struggle to keep your life intact in the prison system is a 24 hour a day job. If you are an inmate who is a little weaker than the rest, and you do not have any friends, homeboys, or brothers in the system, you are definitely on your own.

Case in point: An inmate who did not want to be bothered by anyone, and was not the strongest person mentally or physically, always made a routine day on the compound. Other inmates who watched and observed him were sure to take advantage of his actions and traits, and were sooner or later sure to beat him and rob him of his material items. And that day came.

After buying some goods from the canteen, 3 inmates approached this inmate and told him that he owed them some money, or some of his canteen goods, if he wanted to stay alive or not be beaten on a daily basis.

As I said, this inmate was a total loner and wanted nothing to do or say with anyone else. The loner inmate ran to the housing unit, trying to get the housing sergeant to let him in. At that particular time of day, the housing units were locked, and the only inmates allowed in the Unit were those who were cleaning. If you did not have a pass or a particular job to go to in the housing unit, you would have to stay out on the yard along with everyone else.

The inmate was trying to tell the sergeant about his problem, but the sergeant kept telling the inmate to "go away". This went on for a short period of time, and the sergeant finally gave the inmate a direct order to leave from in front of the Unit. The inmate complied with the sergeant's order and returned to the yard.

Later, while I was on the other end of the compound escorting inmates from a lock down unit to and from the doctor's office and the dental office, I heard a call come over the radio that there was an inmate down in front of the canteen. After I had finished my escort duties, I went to the compound emergency room and saw an inmate laying on a stretcher with all of the medical staff and different officers assisting in giving this inmate CPR. After a short period of time, the doctor had pronounced him dead.

Of course this was the same inmate that tried to get into the housing unit and could not. He had returned to the canteen, and refused again to give up his canteen items to the 3 inmates. He could

have just given up his goods, but he wasn't about to be bullied, so he told the 3 inmates to go "F___ off!"

One of the 3 held the Inmate while another kicked him and hit him in the throat and neck area, and the third inmate robbed him of his goods. This inmate Died for approximately 4 to 5 dollars worth of canteen goods.

The difference of survival maybe should not be associated with one being strong or weak, but maybe with just being stubborn or Stupid.

Strong does not mean that you are muscle bound or that you can lift 300 pounds with ease, because most of the inmates are only strong when they are with their friends. I think the saying is, "strength is in numbers", but it sounds like gangs to me.

When you put anyone of these strong inmates in a room by himself, on a one to one confrontation with any one officer, the inmate will usually end up saying, "it won't happen again sir", or "I'm sorry sir", and he will 'Yes' and 'No sir' you to death.

Usually a Correctional Officer will not counsel an inmate in a room alone, unless he is either huge in stature and muscle bound, or just plain Stupid. He will do it with 1 or more officers in attendance.

Sounds like Strength in numbers, or another gang to me.

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When this particular prison opened up, it was supposed to be a Minimum to Medium custody Prison. That's what the Public in the county was told. And they were told it would hold only a maximum of 900 Medium to minimum violent offenders. But the secretary of corrections knew that the design of this prison was to be a Level 7 prison, which meant it was going to be a Maximum Security prison with the most Physically violent Felons you can imagine.

Then they added a new twist to this type of prison. A Psyche Dorm was opened for the Psychologically Disturbed, along with inmates who also had a minimum amount of time.

So you can imagine that, with all of the different types of inmates in a mixture like this, the Institution was nothing but problems from the Start.

The Close Management Unit is a place where inmates are housed, not only when they get into trouble on the compound; not only when they cannot get along with other inmates at all, but also when they cannot even get along with themselves.

Most of the inmates in Close management have a lot of time on their sentences, I mean 15, 20 years, and a lot even have Life sentences. They truly do not care if they start a riot or a disturbance and they would just as soon stab or try to kill you as to look at you.

Depending on the seriousness of his charge, his attitude and the problems he has caused (or has threatened to cause) on the compound, the inmate housed here would be considered a Management Problem.

The inmates in Close Management cells never come out of the Cell except for a shower 3 times a week, or a haircut when needed, according to the guidelines of the institution hygiene code.

When an inmate is brought from a cell, he is handcuffed behind his back, from a slot that has been cut through the door. Two officers are always present at the door when it is opened. The inmate is escorted to the shower, and when the shower door is shut, the inmate puts his hands through the slot in the shower door, and he is then unhandcuffed. The inmate has 5 minutes to complete his shower, and the water is turned on and off from the control room in the housing unit by an officer.

Before the electric razor, the only thing they had to shave with was a regular plastic razor. Can you imagine giving a Violent inmate who cannot even get along with himself a real razor blade? ...Well they did.

The best home made weapon for an inmate who was Locked Up is a Razor blade and a toothbrush. The toothbrush could be sharpened to a point by rubbing it on the concrete floor of the cell; or if the inmate had a tooth brush, a razor, and access to some matches, he could melt one end of the tooth brush and put the razor in the end of it. Now he had the sharpest, and probably the most feared weapon on the entire compound.

On a daily basis the Medical staff would make their rounds, passing out prescribed medication, going door to door with an officer who had the key to open the food slot door. The Nurse would hand the medication to the inmate after he put his hand outside the slot and he would have to take it in front of the nurse.

During the course of the Nurse's rounds one afternoon, the officer opened the food slot door to give the nurse access to hand the inmate his medication. Instead of the inmate putting his hand through the slot, he had a razor inside a toothbrush and sliced the top of the nurse's hand wide open.

The blame for this incident is that of the inmate of course, BUT, when you let yourself get lax, let your guard down and start to trust an inmate, knowing that he would never do something like that, that's the time when it happens. Giving Inmates razors is not the dumbest thing the state has ever done. But right now I can't think of anything else. But I will.

An inmate in close management could be there from 6 months to 3 years. After a while the isolation works on a person's mind, being in the little room, day after day, never coming out, except for his 5 minute routine hygiene or go to the unit's own recreation Yard.

Inmates are allowed 2 hours a week in the Recreation Yard IF they do not violate any of the rules and regulations of the institution in the Unit or give problems to the officers.

In one instance, an inmate who had been locked up for approximately 2 years, had enough of being locked up. He proceeded to bang on the cell door, cursing at the officers, and told the Sergeant of the unit that it "looks like a good day to die".

This inmate had 1 razor blade in his hand, and 2 or more blades in his mouth, ready to cut the first officer who entered his cell. He had collected Styrofoam cups from his meal trays and had filled them with a mixture of urine and feces that he was going to throw on the officers. He had soaped the entire floor and was waiting for the officers to enter the cell. As soon as they did, he planned to throw a cup of water or the other mixture on the floor, which makes the floor slicker than snot.

He had everything planned to his advantage. He was ready to fight, hurt and kill some officers, and die in the process, or you could say he was just plain stupid, thinking that an officer would just go right in and get feces and urine thrown in their face, and risk getting cut up.

The Captain and one of the Assistant Superintendents went to the cell to try to talk to the inmate, and try to calm him down. In the meantime, the Goon Squad was getting suited up in their rubber suits, masks and gloves, ready to calm the inmate down in the way that they know how to best: Communication Skills Through Body Language, if you get my drift.

The Goon Squad that I mentioned is a team of *Professional Correctional Officers*, trained to deal with incidents of this nature, and they do their job Very Well and are quite Effective.

But if this is what the inmate wanted... he never got it. The Assistant Superintendent talked the inmate into giving up the razors, and pouring out the cups of Crap, and promised him a phone call to his Mommy, and a few other incidentals.

This is just one tiny incident that happens in the Close Management Unit. Basically all of the inmates in this unit act this way. They do not just threaten the officers from behind the closed doors, they curse and threaten each other for hours on end, day in and day out.

Like the inmate who is such a bad ass when he is with his gang, the inmate locked up behind the closed door is even worse. He will threaten the man next to him, across the hall, downstairs from him, just as quick as he would threaten an officer.

The officer cannot do much about the Verbal Abuse from this type of inmate except document his actions. His actions, verbal or physical, have a great effect on whether or not he is released from this housing unit. After a while, some inmates, and all of the officers get tired of hearing this.

In the system, when an inmate threatens another inmate, it's called "Selling Tickets". When the inmate goes to the recreation yard, the other inmate that he has threatened will find out if he can "Cash them IN." The fights were many and frequent.

As of 1997, the State spent a lot of money building fenced in areas behind the Close Management Units so that these inmates would not be in contact with each other. These fenced in areas look like individual, long dog cages.

But the Verbal Abuse continues, inmates cursing the officers and selling each other Tickets. Now they just wait until they get out on the compound and fight, which brings them right back to Close Management, again being locked up for another year or more. Smart!

Some officers on the Midnight shift who got tired of listening to the inmates selling out to each other, along with the screaming and hollering, came up with a bright idea. Do the words, "Thunder Dome" ring a bell? You know the scenario: Two men walk into a room, and only one man leaves. Well it happened right here at this institution.

A sergeant of the Unit figured that this idea would not only quiet things down, but it would relieve a lot of aggression and stress amongst the inmates.

Say if the inmate in cell 301 did not like the inmate in cell 315 and they had been constantly threatening each other, yelling, hollering, and cursing each other for months, it was time to see who could cash in them Tickets. So in the Wee hours of the morning, the doors to cells 301 and 315 were opened electronically from the officer's station by the sergeant or an officer... and 'Thunder Dome' began.

After the fight was over, the winner would walk back to his Cell and the loser would usually have to be dragged back to his.

Thunder dome supposedly went on for quite some time. This entertainment was getting old for someone in that Housing Unit, because it all came to an abrupt stop when someone decided to write the Region office and tell them of all of the Alleged Incidents, in detail.

At first, the investigation was handled at the Institution Level, and the Institution Investigator came to the Conclusion that nothing was going on. Everyone was told that the doors in the Close Management Unit were very 'Unsecure' and 'Loose', and that the inmates could very easily unlock the doors themselves.

When the Regional Director was sent this report, the Department of Corrections sent their top investigators to the institution to look into all of the allegations. During the course of the investigation, an inmate actually showed the prison inspectors that he could take a piece of bed sheeting, tie a knot on one end of it, and put the sheet under the door. By putting the knot, of course, on the outside of the door, and gradually lifting the sheet up between the door and the door frame, when it reached the locking mechanism, the sheet was strong enough to stay together to trip the lock and unlock the door.

After seeing this, the inspectors came to the conclusion that the inmates could have possibly gotten out of their cells and fought with each other for a short period of time and ran back to their cells without the officers seeing this... RIGHT!

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While working in the Close Management unit one evening, an Inmate orderly informed Sgt. Tom and myself that he saw an inmate trying to hang himself. We went to the cell and saw this inmate with the cord from his laundry bag wrapped around his neck, tied at the top of the bunk, trying to hang himself.

With another officer present, I began to untie the rope from around his neck. As I started to untie the cord, the inmate jumped up and with a closed fist, hit me in the face. Startled for just a second, I grabbed the inmate by his upper body, and slammed, OOP's, I mean, placed him on the floor, face first.

We started to wrestle with him for a few seconds, but with myself weighing close to the 300 pound mark and the inmate weighing in close to 130 pounds, he was not a problem at this point.

Sgt. Tom and the Officer assisted me in placing his hands behind his back and handcuffing him and placing leg irons on his ankles. Because the inmate had just tried to hang himself, not taking in account that he had just assaulted me, he was taken to the Mental Health Unit for observation. This inmate would eventually be placed back into the close management unit, where he would stay for another year or year and a half.

This is just another case of an inmate who doesn't care enough whether or not he lives or dies. But when someone tries to help he would just as soon fight or hurt someone else.

At the same time that this was going on, the Lieutenant had a team of four officers suited up in soft body armor, and was going in a cell where an inmate in the wing next to us had a piece of a broom handle, and was trying to break out the light fixture, so he could get to the light bulbs. These bulbs were to make an excellent weapon against the officers when they came into the cell to get him. This inmate was already agitated because the shift prior to our shift had used force on him for throwing a cup of urine on a Sergeant.

The door was opened and the extraction team immediately took care of business, disarming the inmate of the glass bulb and the broom stick, trying to calm him down. Needless to say, when they were done the inmate had no more energy to cause anymore problems. The team did an excellent job, with no casualties.

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Getting away from the Close Management Unit for a while, the State, as I had said earlier had taken one the regular housing units and turned it into a C.S.U. Unit (Crisis Stabilization Unit) and a T.C.U. Unit (Transitional Care Unit). The whole house had to be totally renovated so that an inmate could be cared for who was suspected to have, or did actually have a Mental Problem.

This Institution had enough problems within itself already, without adding the criminally insane. Also the fact that I guess the Public was on a need to know basis about the Mental Unit, and believe me, they did not need to know.

The windows to the doors of the cells were enlarged in each and every cell. Plexiglas was added on the outside of the stairs going up from the floor, to the second floor, so the inmate could not jump from the stairs, and Plexiglas was added all the way around the second floor, so an inmate could not jump, or throw an officer or a staff member from that floor.

The State required that the whole housing unit and every cell be air-conditioned because of the dosage of the Psychotropic Medication that an inmate would take. They wanted the psychologically disturbed inmate to be as comfortable as possible, with the public tax dollars hard at work.

Along with the addition of the Air, each and every cell had a camera so they could be monitored from the nurse's station.

This opened a whole new can of worms for the staff of the Mental health unit. In the summertime, the heat index which usually ranged from 90 degrees plus, to over a 100 degrees, and the humidity at a steady 100%, amazingly changed the seemingly quite normal inmate, who had been dealing with prison life for quite sometime, into someone who all of a sudden started hearing voices and having some strange behavioral problems. You know where I am going with this, right? That new found air conditioning the inmates were hearing about was sounding pretty good, especially in the summertime. I'll get back to that in a little bit.

The state went as far as to close down one of the open bay dorms, which held approximately 150 inmates, renovated it, and turned that into the offices for the Psyche Specialists. All of this Money from the State just all of a sudden flowed in to help the Poor Mentally Challenged inmate who was having a hard time coping with the self-inflicted life that he had set for himself from the outside world.

Think about the cost that the state just endured, hiring 20 Psychological Specialists, half as many assistants for them, Secretaries, transcriptionists, security staff, the Nurses that it would take to run a Unit of that size which would be employed with about 8 Registered Nurses, a handful of Licensed Practical Nurses on every shift, and the extra number of Security Staff Officer's that the unit would have to supply for every shift to keep the nurses and outside staff safe. Also that's not counting the renovation of both housing units, and the cost of just buying the Medication alone just for this one prison. And they were doing this all over the state at other institutions, costing hundreds of millions of dollars.

It took years for a Correctional Officer to get an increase in their wages so he or she could live without working 2 jobs, just to make it. And my point is? How did the state come up with this new found money for these inmates with your tax dollars? Where did it come from? You are paying for an inmate to receive Free personalized and professional care from a Certified Psychiatrist, and also receive Free Psychotropic Medication, as much as it takes to make him a productive and normal inmate again, not a person getting out of prison, but just so he can adapt to prison life. I cannot and will not give false judgment about the psyche Doctors, and would never judge him or her in any way. I would say about one quarter to one half of the doctors in this unit are well aware of the game that the inmate plays to get into this Unit. I know the Doctors are well trained and well versed about the way of life of the inmate and his incarceration. But, there are those who still have that wonderful human feeling and trend of thought that not all people are bad who come to prison, and that not all people can go

through life - or in this case, prison life - and not be depressed, sad, lonely, and having a hard time from their endeavors. That's a bunch of crap!.

Just think: You can go to prison, get out and receive not only a Certified Government welfare check, but also another check from the government for just taking this awful tasting medication that was handed to you, Free of charge, by the Department of Corrections. Isn't that great?! More taxpayers are feeling quite proud right about now. So now, why would you need to leave the house and get that honest productive job that would make you a well adjusted model Citizen, Right?.

Please, don't get me wrong. There are people who actually need the Help and Medication that is offered to them by the state to treat them for their Mental Illness. There are quite a few people that come to prison that are Mentally Unstable. After all, that's how they got in trouble on the street. They could not adjust or handle themselves without their medication that I am sure that they could not afford to buy, nor could they handle any of the problems of the outside world, or hold down a job, or for that matter, some of the Mentally Disturbed people could not even get a job because of their Mental Disability, So who do we BLAME?

When an inmate is brought to this institution, he is given the best treatment available, and if his treatments and medication are not successful, he is transferred to the Main State Mental Prison in Chattahoochee where the check book is even bigger to help the inmate. If the inmate becomes stable enough, he is Transferred back to the institution he came from, and if he is transferred back and doesn't like it there and he hurts himself, the cycle begins all over again.

The inmates who receive Psychotropic medication now has quadrupled from that of, let's say 1995. The scam I mentioned, grows more and more every year, and YES, this is true.

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(Chapter 15)

Searches of inmates, their property and living quarters always reveals a wide variety of Items. These various items range from Apples to Zip Guns...to 'Buck'.

The season for sports always brings out the best in the down home convict winemakers and their talents to make the best brew that you could swallow, IF you have the courage. The easiest wine to make is the Tomato, Potato and Rice Wine because of the easy accessibility of these items from the Kitchen.

If real yeast is not available to make the wines of choice, then any old - and I do mean Very old - bread or pastry is used to help the fermentation process. The homemade wine or, as the convicts call it, "Buck" has to sit and cook in a warm environment in order for it to reach it's proper Fermentation or alcohol level. The buck is cooked in plastic jugs, plastic bags or what ever an inmate can get his hands on.

After everything is achieved, the buck is distributed and sold, and passed out in any kind or type of container that is available.

No one, and I mean *no one*, can say, "I've seen it all" or that you've been there or done all that. You will never see it all, and should never say that you cannot be taught anything, anymore than what you already know. Even with the number of years of experience, I have never stopped learning n or being amazed at what inmates will think of or do next.

During a search for some Buck on a weekend night, during a Sports playoff game during which the buck usually flows quite freely, Buck was found in many different containers, but none of the finds was as surprisingly hidden, or nothing less than obvious, or just plain dumb-founding as the one I am going to tell you about.

This certain Dorm housed mainly the handicapped inmates. It was also the dorm where the kitchen help slept. It was famous for officers being able to find a lot of homemade wine and other kinds of contraband there.

When you see an inmate in a wheelchair with a Catheter bag hooked to the side of it, anybody, I don't care who you are, gloves on or not, you are not going to touch that bag, whether it is empty or full...Except for the leaky Catheter bag that smells like Buck.

After seeing this, I would say that this is the lowest, most disgusting, nastiest way to store and pass out the homemade brew. Imagine, here is a bag that some inmate has not only urinated in, but the tube the Buck is poured from was stuck, at sometime or another, in his Penis.

I don't care how much you wash the bag, and think it's clean, not to mention whatever disease or diseases he may or may not have had... If I was a very thirsty inmate, and that was the last thing on earth to drink, I would have to just go ahead and die before I would drink a cup of buck from someone's Catheter bag.

Like I said, if you think you've seen it all, you're Wrong!

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LIFE AND TIMES OF A CORRECTIONAL OFFICER

By R. Mark Shepard

(Chapter 16)

Most of the Tax paying citizens in this state, or any other state, do not understand what a Correctional Officer has to encounter, and what they have to do every day. They think that Correctional Officers are just a lower form of Law Enforcement. They think that we are just a bunch of people with a high school Diploma and a few of hours of State Training, and that qualifies us to baby-sit thousands of Convicted criminals.

I have been known to get into trouble by voicing my opinion, or just telling someone what I think of their so-called opinion. But on a nicer note, I usually tell them not to judge me until they have walked a mile in my shoes as a Correctional Officer.

It is true that we are just Glorified Baby-sitters, but mostly we are, on a daily basis, Psychologists, Social workers, and most of all, Human Beings.

We've got to have a totally different attitude towards the job and the way we handle ourselves because of the hundreds of different scenarios and situations that we encounter every minute of everyday that would drive the normal unknowing and uneducated judgmental taxpayer into a frenzy.

The totally different attitude we take towards our job makes us human enough to do our job, and after 8 hours we walk out of that gate and go back to our families, hopefully with a different attitude and sense about ourselves.

But, we are only human, and we sometimes forget to leave The Work Place and those problems at work, just as sometimes we forget to leave the domestic problems that we encounter at home, at home.

You see, we are just like the normal Joe or the person employed by the sheriff's Department, or the City Police, or the Highway Patrol. We are HUMAN: We like to drink our beer, have picnics, go to parties and try to enjoy each other's company. And yes, sometimes we do make our little mistakes no matter what Law enforcement job we are employed at.

There are a few officers that I have seen, who have been caught doing the everyday stupid little moves, like getting caught drinking and driving, shooting live rounds of ammunition in the air from their Illegal Fully-automatic weapons on certain holidays, or having a Cross burning party after shift, in uniform on State property, just to relieve some stress or a little anxiety. We all know that this is not the way to relieve stress, but it happens.

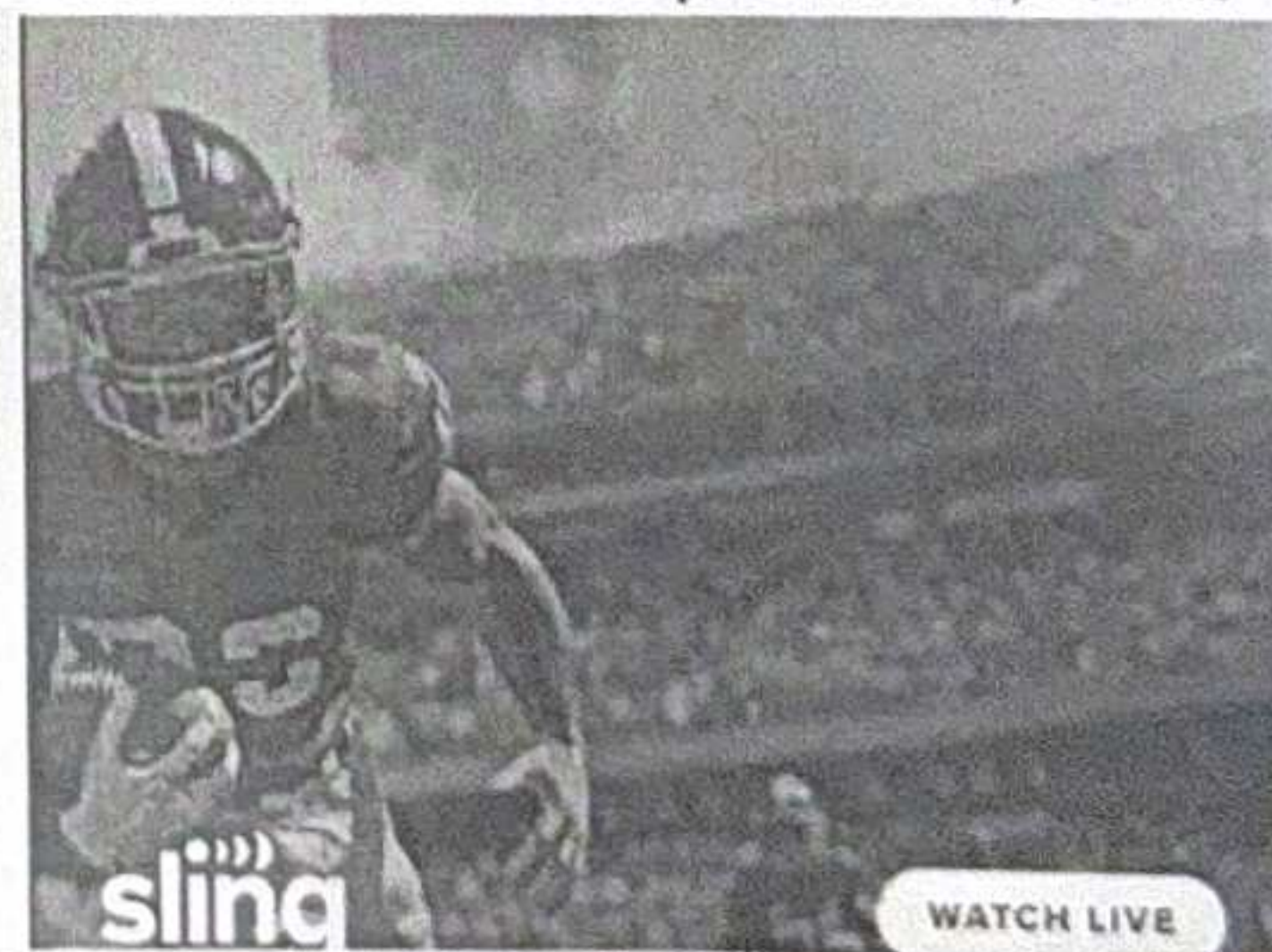
We even had an Assistant Superintendent who was enjoying an evening out, trying to relieve a little stress by driving north in the south bound lane on a major highway. Of course he did have a little more to drink than the average casual drinker.

After about 30 minutes of trying to stop this man from killing himself or other innocent drivers and pedestrians, he was taken to the Jail, where he not only relieved a little stress, but relieved his AD front of God and everyone who was present.

But he did apologize and he wiped up the Fluid with his shirt and then is on the Jail Security Camera, you are right, it is.

Of course being the survivor that he is, and after sleeping off the excess one of the worst prisons in the State, and just Knowing the right person is empowered in his position, and not much else became of that.

Everyone at one time or another has watched on television the so-called the Correctional Officer. All you see is the Shotgun toting guard either : disorderly convict, or you might see the guard walking the prison comp



the other hand, as if to warn the convict that if he gets out of line, he will be punished right on the spot, in front of other guards and other prisoners, and surely be taught that valuable lesson of how to be good and respectful towards the guard.

I've got news for you, that's NOT how it is! What I am about to tell you in the next chapter is how it really is, and how my long career as a Correctional Officer ended.

And how the justice system really works, especially for those who have worked hard their entire life, telling the truth and have never been in trouble doing the job the right way.

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By R. Mark Shepard

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The daily job assignment you must to go as a Correctional Officer may turn out to be your worst fear or nightmare, and you will not even realize it until you have actually lived through it.

It will be that simple task, or routine assignment that you do 20 times a day, 5 days a week, for years. You won't even know what you have done until it's over, and then you probably won't even think much about it because you are too used to the System and how it operates, and how you think you can make it work for you.

You think you know how to work with your closest fellow officers, and you think that they, the chosen few whom you wish to work with, will stand behind you no matter what. You have faith that they are all of the Inner Protection you need to help you get through the everyday incident or problems that will arise and you believe that you will prevail from it all, without any repercussion from superiors or the investigation that it has formed.

This kind of thinking comes from being subjected to years of Conformity on the job, and sometimes just plain NOT using our God given talent of Common Sense that I have been talking about throughout this book.

Myself and Sgt. Tom sometimes have not always made the best decisions, but we don't and never have formed opinions, just words, so that we would make sure that we would be walking out of the Front gate that we came in from, and not carried out on a stretcher.

We have made our share of mistakes, but Sgt. Tom and Myself have ALWAYS stuck together, and talked about what we would do in any situation. Some of our Conversations would be lengthy, and others would be just plain short words of so-called wisdom we would share together while running to help save someone, or while making a quick plan of attack, hoping to survive a bad situation.

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(Chapter 18)

On one of those Routine 4 to 12 shifts, Sgt. Tom and myself were performing our rounds as inside Security Officers. Our job that evening was to check doors that were supposed to be secure, to walk the fence line inside and outside the prison to check for any discrepancies, and basically to perform the tasks assigned to us according to our job assignment.

But this night would turn our lives around forever: Our jobs, our lifestyles and integrity and honor would be judged and challenged by everyone rather involved or not. Fellow officers and their families would label us just for doing our job, following orders, and at the same time participating in a situation that we did not have any control over.

We made decisions together, to tell the truth; to use our human instincts, to keep integrity in our jobs and our reputations as firm but fair officers intact, to just be good Correctional Officers.

That one evening, one of the Head prison inspectors had notified our institution that we would be receiving an inmate from a Central Florida Prison. This inmate was supposed to have severely assaulted a Correctional Officer.

The Captain on our shift had called the O.I.C. at the Central Florida Institution to find out what had actually happened. The Captain had called Sgt. Tom and myself into his office and told us that we were receiving an inmate who was very violent and dangerous. He went on to explain that this inmate, from what he could gather from the other Institution, had bitten off a Piece of Flesh from an Officer's face, and then looked at the Officer and told him, "I've got Aids and now you do too," and then started laughing.

At this time, this is all that Sgt. Tom and myself knew about this inmate. The Captain had told Sgt. Tom and myself that he had already talked to some of the other officers, and that when the Inmate arrived, he would be dealt with.

This means that the Inmate would be rushed through the receiving procedure, then hurried to the Medical Department for his Pre-Confinement check, which would be very brief, and then

rushed to the Cell where he would be Dealt With with some type of Corporal Punishment by us and the Transport Officers from the other institution in retaliation for biting the Fellow Officer.

Everyone was anxiously awaiting his arrival, except for Sgt. Tom and myself. We knew what kind of situation that this could turn into, and we had even talked amongst ourselves and wondered why the inspector would transfer this inmate to our Institution, instead of another closer institution with the same capability and capacities.

Upon arrival of this Dangerous and Vicious inmate that we had been told about, there was Sgt. Tom, myself, the Captain, the Two transport officers from the other institution, and 3 more Officers from our prison to greet him.

When this inmate stepped out of the Van, Sgt. Tom and myself just looked at one another and figured out right away that this Not-so-very-big inmate who looked like he had not seen much personal hygiene lately, probably had one of those Little Man attitudes, and apparently was trying to prove to himself how much of a tough guy he was by injuring an Officer.

The inmate had just stepped through the gate when the Captain approached him and asked him if he thought that he was some kind of Bad Ass inmate who thinks that he can just go around and bite or hurt anyone he wanted to, especially an officer. The Inmate said, "No sir." The Captain returned by saying, "It wouldn't bother me one bit if I had to call your mother and tell her that you were dead."

The Captain then told the inmate that if he hit, kicked, *Bit*, punched or attempted any kind of Physical Violence towards any one of his officers, that the inmate would be dealt with and severely punished. Then the Captain asked the inmate if he understood that, and the inmate said, "Yes sir."

After taking off the other Institution's restraints and putting ours on, the inmate was quickly identified by the Control Room Officer, and then rushed to the Medical Department for his pre-confinement check. On the way to Medical, the inmate was bounced off of a door or two, you know, that kind of door that wouldn't open properly, or fast enough?

When we got to Medical Department, the Nurse already had the inmate's Name and DC number, and told us to weigh him. Then the Captain said, "That's enough, get him out of here and take him to the Confinement Unit."

The inmate was rushed at a *very* quick pace across the Compound, running into that darn steel gate door that wouldn't open properly. When we arrived at the Confinement Unit, the Inmate was going so fast that he ran right into the front door of The Confinement Unit.

When we arrived inside, the Sergeant of the housing unit and his officer were waiting for us, and took over the escort of the inmate. After hitting the front door of the housing unit, the inmate accidentally hit another door on the inside of the unit, just before entering the Cell block. The inmate was then rushed up the stairway, which his feet never touched, to the second floor, to his assigned cell.

The sergeant of the house and myself stepped into the cell with the inmate, and before the Sergeant could take his handcuffs off, the House Officer, who happens to be a very large and very strong man, pushed the inmate against the back wall of the cell with enough force that the little holes in the metal grate made impressions on the inmate's right shoulder.

I stood the inmate back up on his feet and asked the sergeant to take the inmate's handcuffs off because I had something that I wanted say to this inmate. With the inmate's hands free so

he could show me how bad he really was if he wanted to, he just stood there waiting to see if I was going to hit him or touch him in any way.

I explained to him, very factually that as long as he did his time here at this Institution not causing any problems, disrespecting officers or making any trouble at all, there would be no problems. I asked him if he did not understand anything that I explained to him, to let me know Right away!

I then Slightly, with little effort, put my fist on his right shoulder and pushed him in his chest, causing him little or no pain. Trust me, without bragging, if I hit this scared whipped little piece of human being, he would not be getting back up from one of my non-'slightly' touches or pushes. The inmate responded, looking directly at me, and saying, "yes" he did understand what I was saying. "Enough said," from myself, and I backed out of the Cell.

Sgt. Tom went in so he could unlock and take off the leg irons that the inmate still had on from the transport. The House Sergeant and his very large officer who were in the cell at the time of my little speech, stayed in the cell. As Sgt. Tom reached down to unlock the Restraints, the Large Officer and his Sergeant starting hitting this inmate unlike anything I've ever seen before.

I've seen officers have to jump on inmates to defend themselves and take certain courses of action in order to survive in different situations. After all, it usually comes down to just that, Survival, you or them, living or dying.

I had realized that this inmate was going to get paid back by some officers for biting a fellow officer from another Institution, But I wasn't sure how much until I saw this Sergeant and his officer beating this inmate, and I don't mean hitting him with just a little punch here and a slap there. These two had this inmate twisted and bent over the lower steel bunk beating the crap out of him.

Knowing the size and the strength of the officer that was paying this inmate back for his actions at the other institution, I figured that this would not go on for very long. And the Captain, who set this up in the first place, and gave the orders, finally figured out that it was in the best interest of his shift not to beat this man to death the first night he had arrived. Finally he told the sergeant and the officer that it was time to stop beating him.

After they had stopped, the one *brave* officer from the other institution looked at his Sergeant and the Captain, and went into the cell and hit the inmate in the head twice, and said, "That's for my friend that you bit."

Rules and Regulations state that an unruly inmate is to be stripped of all of his material items, including his mattress, his Clothes and undergarments. This inmate was stripped down to Nothing but a steel bunk. After everyone left the cell, everyone went into the officer's station in the Confinement Unit to wash up and check for any injuries that might have occurred.

Now the Captain started to use his brain. He gathered everyone together, except for the transport officers, and ordered everyone involved who had any kind of contact with this inmate, to write a use of force report against the inmate, just in case the inmate got brave in the morning, and wanted to report to another shift that we had beat him or abused him in any way.

The stories from each officer were to be basically the same, but had to be put in a different context, to show the Institution Inspector and the Superintendent that this inmate gave us nothing but problems from the time he had stepped off of the transport van until the Cell door was secure.

These fabricated stories of fiction that we wrote, per the captain, were started by him and as we were writing them, he would critic our every sentence and word put on paper so that there would be no errors or discrepancies in any of the Statements made by all officers involved.

After all of the paper work was prepared and read over and over again by the Captain, he had asked if everyone was OK, and told us that we ALL would have to stick together, and not waver from any of the stories that he had compiled for the incident.

The only thing that the Captain did not tell us is that all of the documents that everyone had just falsified were totally Different and that no one else actually knew what the other one had written, except that the inmate was unruly and violent, threatening the lives of all he had come in contact with when he arrived.

For example, Sgt. Tom's statement and mine were the same, because we were appointed the escorting officers as soon as the inmate stepped off of the van. The Captain ordered us to write that, while Sgt. Tom and myself were escorting the inmate from the Medical Department to the Confinement Unit, the Inmate was supposed to have turned to Sgt. Tom and spit at him, trying to give Sgt Tom the virus, and when Sgt. Tom turned to avoid the bodily fluids, I was supposed to have slammed the inmate to the ground and take control of him so he could not spit on anyone else. This of course would explain some of the marks and redness on the head or body after my 300 plus pounds of body weight laid on him waiting for help.

Sgt. Tom and myself were team players and would always stand by one another, or another officer if he was in trouble. But this was rather unsettling to us, because we both knew deep down that this Falsification of Records, was something that we had Never done before. We have made statements before that we may have embellished on the truth a little, but I am here to tell you now, we have NEVER, EVER, Falsified a document or even thought of Falsifying any of our paper work in this Method, nor had we ever been ordered to do this before.

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By R. Mark Shepard

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It was at least two or three months later before the investigation of this incident began. It started with Subpoenas for all of the officers of the shift to report to the State Attorney's Office 'with your lawyer, if you had one'. This was supposed to be an Informal hearing with one of the State's Prison Inspectors, the Investigator from the State Attorney's office, and a member of the F.D.L.E., Florida Department of Law Enforcement.

What I have not told you yet, is that after that fateful first night, for the next 3 or 4 days, various officers on different shifts decided that this inmate should be further punished, and be accountable for his actions from biting a fellow officer. So the things that had went on, unreported of course, were things such as making the inmate get on his knees with his nose resting on the concrete floor and putting his hands behind his back for hours, and officers telling him that if he moved 1 inch, that they would come into the cell and kick him to sleep.

The officers told the inmate that they wanted him to know what pain felt like, just as the officer did that he had bitten and probably given the aids virus to. They wanted him to feel pain everyday of his waking moments here at this institution.

Other things that the inmate encountered were his meals were sent to him Via Air Mail: In other words, when the food tray was placed on the slot in the cell, the officer would give it a good shove so it would hit the floor, or the officer would put his arm in the slot along with the food tray and throw the food tray at the inmate. It was documented that the inmate was afforded the Opportunity to eat, and if he didn't, Oh Well!

After about the fourth day of the small torments that I have mentioned, and the others I have no idea about, the inmate could not handle this system anymore. He had gotten a hold of a piece of plastic, sharpened it, and began cutting himself on all of his veins that he thought might end his life the quickest.

He apparently had a lot of time to do this, because when the officer found him, he was lying in a pool of blood, or should I say a puddle of blood. The whole Cell floor was covered from corner to corner.

The officer Immediately told the Sergeant, and the Medical Department was notified. Before going into the cell, everyone had suited up to take that extra precaution because of the inmate being HIV Positive. When the inmate was brought out of the cell, the medical staff was amazed that the inmate was still alive because he had lost so much blood.

The inmate was taken to the infirmary and the head nurse checked him out, and for some reason, even with all of the blood loss and all of the cuts and bite marks - Yes, I said bite marks: The inmate had tried to bite through the cuts that he had made, and chew his veins - the inmate was NOT transported to the local hospital, so that he could be stitched up. Instead, the Nurse put strips on his skin to close the wounds, and dressing over the strips, because the Head Doctor of the institution plainly said over the phone to the nurse, that the inmate would probably last until the morning, and that the Doctor would stitch him up when he came in at 8:00 am.

As I have previously said, when an inmate tries to take his own life, he is placed in the CSU unit for further observation and care to make sure he does not try to hurt himself again. And he is usually given a large quantity of medicine to help him relax.

Even with all of the blood loss that this inmate had sustained, he actually walked to the CSU unit with a large escort of officers. When he arrived, he was placed on the highest suicide watch anyone can be on. He was strapped to a bed on his back, naked, with his hands and feet at each corner of the bed so he could no longer hurt himself.

Because I was not physically there, I cannot tell you any more about what happened in the C.S.U. unit that night. The next morning I got a call at home from an officer who told me that "the inmate who tried to kill himself the night before has

died".

Sgt. Tom and myself had the same days off, and when we came back to work, the whole Buzz amongst the officers was about the Big Investigation in the C.S.U. Unit and what had happened there the night the inmate tried to commit suicide.

Between Sgt. Tom and myself, we were glad that we were not involved with that mess, because we were still thinking about our mess with this same inmate four days earlier, lying, writing false reports trying to cover our tracks, Per the Captain.

With the subpoenas being handed out, and all of the officers calling their PBA lawyers, this investigation was going to take on a whole new meaning. And what we didn't know is that some of the officers that we were associated with four days earlier were the ones who were also involved the night the inmate cut himself.

The captain of our shift asked Sgt. Tom and myself if we were going to be all right, and wanted to know if we were going to hang in there and basically, stick with the Original Story that we had already Falsified. From what we could gather from talking to all of the other officers who were interviewed, everyone, and I mean *everyone*, lied to the Investigators at the first interview.

Everyone had stood fast and stuck together with their original story of what had happened to the inmate that came to our Institution four days before he had decided to try to kill himself, *supposedly*. Sgt. Tom and myself could only give them the false details of what went on when he had arrived, and only that.

Six or Seven months went by before we heard anything about this investigation. WE thought that it was over with and that all of the paper work was completed and this incident would be swept under the rug, just like any of the other incidents that have happened here, or anywhere else. I myself had enough time in the system that I could Retire. My Body was physically breaking down to the point where I could not run anymore. My knees were full of Arthritis and previous injuries from when I was a child, which prevented me from exercising my joints properly. I always said that if I could not run to help save another officer's life who was in danger, I was no good to him/her or myself or the System, so I retired.

One day out of the blue, the Head Investigator for the State's Attorney's Office showed up at my front door and handed me a subpoena to go before a Grand Jury to tell them what had happened the night the inmate came to our prison.

The investigator told me that he knew that Sgt. Tom and myself had lied in some capacity, because he had talked to other State Prison Investigators, and they had told him that Sgt. Tom and myself were always straight up with them, with all of the reports, and that this situation sounds like something that we would not Voluntarily do, not without someone ordering us, or threatening us, and that we were probably in the wrong place at the wrong time with the wrong people in charge.

The Investigator told me that the worst thing that we could do is lie to a Grand Jury. Here it comes, the investigator said. "If you tell us the truth, BEFORE you go to the grand jury, you will NOT be charged or prosecuted." So I told him that I would talk to Sgt. Tom and get back to him and let him know.

The conversation between Sgt. Tom and myself would be quite lengthy. I mean after all, this investigator had told me in detail exactly what had occurred from the time the inmate stepped off the Van, to the time that the Captain ordered us to write the false reports, IN DETAIL. So, apparently someone who had been with us had gone to the investigators and confessed everything that had really happened, IN DETAIL.

Already not having a clear conscious from the first interview, we both had decided that it was in our best interest, and to have a clear conscious, to tell the truth, which we should have done from the beginning. But you as the public have to remember, that we had to work with this same captain and these same officers everyday, and if you don't think that our jobs, our even our lives weren't on the line from within, you are wrong.

If this Captain got the least bit of a scent that we were about to tell the truth, we would have not only been assigned to the worst detail in the system, we would be black-balled by our fellow workers, and set up to make us look like the Dirtiest Officers that ever existed - and if you think that this type of thing does not exist, well, it does.

After Sgt. Tom and myself had agreed with each other to be the Professional Correctional Officers that we have always tried to be, we had decided to tell the truth. We were sure that this was the only way to remain and go on through life with our dignity intact, and be human at the same time, no matter what anyone or Officer said, or names that we were called. It made no difference: We were telling the truth, which gave us now a clear conscious of this incident. We never had to struggle with any form of guilt before for doing our job, no matter the situation.

Our first meeting with the head federal Prosecutor and Two Investigators was nothing more than normal, seeing that they already knew the truth, Sgt. Tom and myself led them on the most direct path to the truth. They talked to us separate, and got the same facts.

We were called in a week later for a lie detector test. Sgt. Tom was first and took the test. They had taken me into a room and asked me the same general questions that we had gone over before, and as they tried to play their little game of how my story didn't match that of Sgt. Tom, well.....That didn't work. I ended up *Not* taking the polygraph test. They said they truly believed me, and that I was telling the truth. I responded by saying, "Why wouldn't you, after all we came forward to tell the truth". They stammered and stuttered for a while and said that they just wanted to make sure that you were truthful.

We had already figured out that they would separate us, and play one against the other and try that psychological game. But no matter what questions they asked us, or tests they gave us, it always came up the same, The TRUTH. The one lead investigator stated that he had never seen two people either stick together as much as Sgt. Tom and myself, or it was just a fact that we were telling the truth. He said it usually takes some time to separate the truth from a lie between two people, and they had always had been very successful in doing so, but there was no denying that we were as truthful and as sure about what we had said and done, or didn't do, as any two people could be.

The whole time we had spent with the Investigators and the Federal Prosecutor, they constantly reminded us that we were still on the GOOD list, and we had nothing to worry about.

Sgt. Tom was the first witness to go into the grand jury room. My testimony took all of 7 to 8 minutes, tops. When completed the head prosecutor shook our hands and thanked us for all of our help, and sent us on our way.

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(Chapter 20)

A couple of months passed and we heard nothing about the outcome of the decision that the grand jury had made. Then Sgt. Tom and I were called in to the Federal Prosecutors office for a meeting, that's it, nothing else was said. The next day we had gone to the office, and everyone that we had been talking to for months was there, with a kind of somber look on their faces. The Lead prosecutor told us that what they were about to say, wasn't easy, and that they absolutely did everything in their power to prevent it. Waiting on more, we said OK and get to the point. The investigator said that someone from the Head of the Department of Corrections had gone to Washington and they were sending another Federal Prosecutor down to assist with the case, because the only legitimate statements that they had for the prosecution were that of Sgt. Tom and myself. This apparently did not sit well with someone at the Head office, whom ever that be, and it wasn't enough to prosecute and convict the people that they really wanted to pay for the crime, so. The Investigators said that everyone, including Sgt. Tom and myself were being charged.

WE could not believe this, we worked hard with these officials, telling the truth to them and a grand jury, being promised that we were on the, GOOD LIST, and now we were facing up to 10 years, in Federal Prison, for TELLING THE TRUTH. Well....needless to say, our stomachs turned inside out, and in knots with disbelief.

How could we have been betrayed, after coming clean, never Having been in trouble at work, never an oral reprimand or written reprimands of any kind, always doing our job effectively trying to be that firm but fair officer, receiving outstanding performance appraisals, and being a good citizen outside of our job.

The investigators apologized and apologized, they said that there was nothing that they could do to help us, that this came from the highest level of office in the government, and that when the trial was over, and if we had to go to prison, that they would TRY to make sure that we would not go to a prison with your everyday murders, rapist and killers. But we would ALMOST be sure to be sent to a prison that housed just, Convicted Cops. Sgt. Tom and I just said, "Gee thanks". How else were we suppose to feel. We told the truth about not only what injustices other people had done, but also confessed to the injustices that we had done.

Do you see any Bargaining power here?, if we wanted to, NO. The investigators also told us that we would be getting a courtesy call at home when we were to be arrested, so that we could just turn ourselves in Voluntarily, instead of being handcuffed, and stuffed into a patrol car. Again we said, "gee thanks".

The Disbelief from what had just happened was unreal. We HAD done the right thing, by telling the truth, and having a clear conscious about it.

The evening before we were told to report to the courthouse and turn ourselves in, we had no idea what was in-store for us.

When we were officially arrested, we were put in the same cell as the other officers that were arrested. During the process of the initial booking procedure, the investigators came in and told Sgt. Tom and myself that we would be going home as soon as all of us had seen the judge, but he didn't know about the others. We were told that we would be put on a \$50,000 Signature Bond and set free. So as we went before the judge, we quickly learned that the Signature Bond was, Again, no special treatment. The Judge gave all of he officers that special \$50,000 Signature Bond.

Sgt. Tom and I filled out the necessary paperwork to prove that we could not afford an attorney, and was appointed an attorney on the spot. The only thing is that they didn't tell us where the attorney's office was located, or what City. I can say that I was lucky, my attorney was only about an hour ride away. But Sgt. Tom's attorney was at least a 3 hr. ride away from home. And as all appointed attorney's are, you are at their mercy. So the contact to the lawyers was limited but the advice was there. Maybe if we had the Big Bucks to pay them they might have been a little more receptive, but they did their best.

Now it is the Taxpayers turn to shell out the coin, after all, we were just about to that inmate stage in life for telling the truth.

When the Trial started, I was the First one on the Stand. I'm not sure why, but I had to lead off the accounting of the first day that the inmate arrived at our prison. That's all I could testify to, because that's all of the contact I had with the inmate.

It's enough being nervous facing 1 defense attorney, but we had 3 tables full, and their clients of those fancy Suits that you have to listen to and answer their questions. I don't wish that on anyone. Sgt. Tom was the next one on the stand, and his Testimony was just as lengthy as mine was. We both were surely glad when our time was up.

After testifying, you always go back in your mind and find the small things that you said wrong, or that question that you answered wrong. It's always that one word that changes the whole context of your testimony.

Now the only thing we had to do was to wait to see what outcome of the trial was, and to see what kind of sentence we would receive. The outcome of the trial could have effected our sentencing. In Short, the testimony of the other officers who were there in the CSU unit the night the inmate was strapped down on the bed, was nothing less than shocking.

Other Testimonies against the accused were of the accused hitting the inmate repeatedly on his chest, and his face, pulling hairs from his eye brows 1 by 1, kicking him in the Genitals numerous times, and hitting his open wounds several times. The reporters in the courtroom also stated that the accused had punched the inmate in the throat several times and jerked his head back so far that his head could not be lifted up on his own.

But when all was done, the cause of death was still reported to be that his blood loss was too great to sustain any normal functions. Believe what you may!.

The whole trial lasted about a week and it took the jury only a couple of hours for their Verdict. Needless to say, the jury said that the Prosecutors did not make their case with enough substantial evidence, and all of the accused were found - Not Guilty!.

This of course did not make any difference to Sgt. Tom or myself, because we were still facing Federal time. We still had a clear conscious about telling the truth, and Yes, our dignity was still intact and all of the rest who lied have to live with it the rest of their lives for what they have done, and when they die, they will be Judged.

There is one thing that still puzzled me and Sgt. Tom, that is the officers that were in the cell at the CSU unit who testified against the accused, and were involved in the last so called beating, were not charged, and did not have to testify before the grand jury. And they also lied at the first meeting of the Investigation. What power to have against the Federal Government.

Our fate was not known until 4 months later. When we went before the judge for our sentencing, our pre-sentence report showed that we had never been in trouble, and were until now, upstanding citizens of the community, and with our employer.

To make a long story short we received 3 years probation, 100 hours of community service and apologized to the family of the inmate and our family's, for putting them through so much anguish and Stress.

Our attorney's thanked us for pleading out, and making their job so much easier, and I am sure they thanked the federal government and the Taxpayers for all of the Government money for doing Something.

NO, just kidding, they did help, they were there, and they meant well.

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By R. Mark Shepard

(Chapter 21)

Now that the worst days were over for Sgt. Tom and myself, our lives go on just as normally as anyone else's....

Except for the Inmate's Mother, who thought that all parties involved were not properly punished. As any grieving family member would do, she filed a Civil Law Suit and wanted compensation for her son's alleged torture and Death. And according to her and her attorney, everyone was going to pay, and I don't mean with prison time. The Civil Suit demanded that everyone, guilty or innocent, was going to pay her a Tidy Sum of Money.

To give you a little background of this loving mother. First let me tell you that when her son was arrested for his Heinous crime, she never went to court to support him. When he was found guilty, she moved out of the state, because of the embarrassment I guess that he put on the family name, and she wanted nothing to do with him again, disowning him and his existence.

But when someone contacted her and told her that her son had passed away in prison, and that there might be signs of physical abuse allegedly caused by the prison staff, she became very concerned about her poor son.

She was also interviewed over the local Television Station expressing her concerns (with a smile on her face) about him, and she could not believe the allegations and the rumors she had heard about the officers torturing or even beating her beloved son to death that she cared so much for..

OK, that's enough, NOW for the truth. When the Prison Chaplain notified the mother the morning of her son's death, the Chaplain made sure in advance that there was someone there at her house for her emotional needs. He didn't want to just blurt it out and be responsible for her fainting or having some type of breakdown. But what he heard, was something that even he couldn't believe.

When the Chaplain told her that he was sorry about her son who had passed away, she responded by saying, "I don't have a son, and I don't care."

The Chaplain was kind of shocked and asked her what she wanted to do with the remains, and she said, "I don't care what you do with him, I don't have anything to do with him," and she hung up.

But as I said earlier, when someone told her what the allegations were, she became this wonderful loving mother with all the concerns in the world for her poor son.

It didn't take long for one of the attorneys for the accused to get ahold of that conversation, and before you know it, the Civil Suit was mysteriously settled, and the Poor Mother was happy with her little six figure sum that the state offered her and everything just disappeared. Imagine that!

How do I know this? Well let's just say that one attorney that I had the utmost respect for was also one who cross examined me at the trial. He called me and told me that he had done all of the bargaining between the state and the mother's attorney, and that everyone would be happy.

When I received the Notification that it was definitely final, I called that particular attorney and told him, "You are THE MAN!"

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LIFE AND TIMES OF A CORRECTIONAL OFFICER

By R. Mark Shepard

(Chapter 22: Conclusions and Final Thoughts)

One day you are going to sit down and realize that it does take a unique and strange individual to be a Correctional Officer. You will realize that no matter how much time you do working as a Correctional Officer, the environment around you will effect you, and it will make you lose your senses. You will lose your sense of Self-discipline, and Self dignity. You will start talking and thinking like the people that you are around everyday and you will have no purpose and no caring about how the way life should be, outside of the Prison System, just because you are working in the Prison System.

You will start Cursing as Fluently as you think, just like them, and your normal conversation at home or anywhere else will start and end with 'F___ this', or 'F___ that', along with, 'so what', or 'who gives a S___'. The reality of carrying on that normal conversation will slip away, just as fast as your faith.

No matter how strong you think that your faith in God is, believe this, you WILL slip away, and you WILL Fall, and all of your faith will fall too, because of the environment that you work in here in the prison system. IT will never change, it will make your relationship with your Family that Rocky road you never wanted to go down. All of your frustrations and anxieties will surface, and the monster that takes away your self-respect and self-perseverance will appear from the Hell Hole environment that you work in here in the Prison System.

When you get that job as a Correctional Officer, and you put that shirt on that gives you the power to take control, and maintain that self-discipline, GOOD LUCK!. But don't ever forget where you came from or who you are, because no one will help you, but YOU. Don't worry or fret if you've made a mistake, you're human. You better worry about what goes on around you, and what someone is about to do to you, because it will happen.

If you cannot handle any of the things that you have heard about throughout this book, you will not succeed as a Correctional Officer in the Prison System. Even if you have any doubts about the job, or you think that you are going to change the system to make it a better place to work, and create peace and harmony amongst you and your fellow officers, you are sadly mistaken.

But if you try, you must maintain and take control of yourself, mentally and physically, and hold on to your Beliefs, without losing them, or your Scruples. You must listen to the people who know, and have endured the SO CALLED System, and Survived, and even they do not know all of the answers. You must listen, losing your Faith, losing face with your family and friends is probably the most important thing that you can, and will lose.

It Will happen!

That's how it is in the Department of Corrections.

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